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Frontend Interview-Day Cheat Sheet

One printable page. Bring it to the whiteboard, not the interview.

The 6-box whiteboard (draw these before you draw architecture)

1. Users and critical journey
Primary user, entry point, success state, highest-cost failure.

2. Constraints and scale
Devices, networks, regions, traffic, freshness, security, accessibility.

3. Quality priorities
Rank performance, availability, consistency, autonomy, cost, time.

4. Runtime and ownership
Rendering, shell, modules, API/BFF, caches, identity, delivery, teams.

5. Failure and recovery
Timeout, retry, partial data, offline, stale client, rollback.

6. Evidence
Budgets, service objectives, telemetry, tests, pilot, review trigger.

The 10 checks to run before you stop

1. Did I identify the primary user and journey?
2. Did I state assumptions instead of hiding them?
3. Did I rank the quality attributes?
4. Did I choose boundaries that match ownership?
5. Did I separate server, URL, UI, and persisted state?
6. Did I define cache freshness and invalidation?
7. Did I show a degraded mode and recovery?
8. Did I cover security and accessibility?
9. Did I name field metrics and release guardrails?
10. Did I summarize the biggest trade-off?

5 phrases that buy thinking time

"I will make one assumption and test it with you."

"The critical path I am optimizing is..."

"There are two viable options; the deciding constraint is..."

"Before adding a service, I want to show the failure mode."

"The evidence that would change this decision is..."

Want the full 60 questions? The Frontend System Design Interview Playbook ($19)

bittalk.gumroad.com/l/frontend-interview-playbook

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